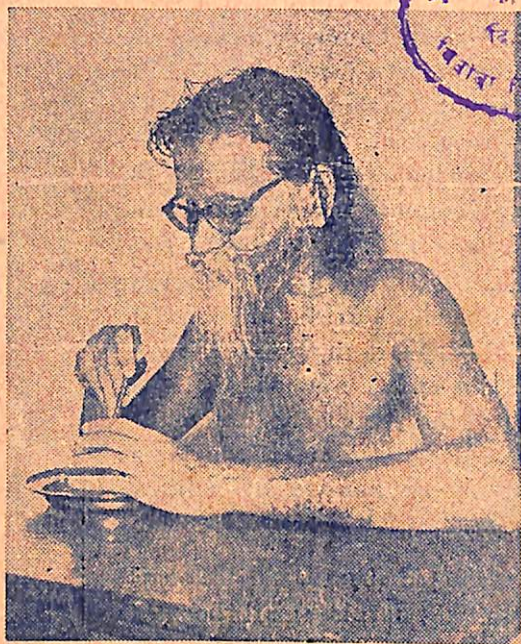


Bhoodan To Gram-dan

Acharya Vinoba



Sarvodaya Prachuralaya

(Akhila Bharath Sarva Seva Sangh)

TANJORE

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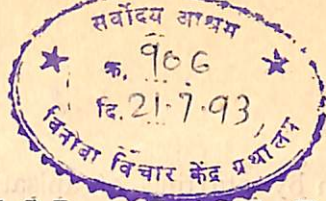
www.vinoba.in

Bhoodan Booklet E-12/34,000

The Bhoodan Yagna has taken a new turn ever since the last Sarvodaya Sammelan at Puri in March '55. The Land-Gift Movement for the landless has logically culminated in the Gram-dan or whole gift of villages. In Orissa, hundreds of villages offered themselves for the Gram-dan with great enthusiasm. This is another revelation of the superior urge in man to surrender his all to the village community even as Vinobaji found earlier in Pochampalli five years ago. The speeches of Acharya Vinoba since the Puri Sammelan till the end of his yatra in Orissa throw a flood of light on the new phase of the movement for the realization of Sarvodaya Social Order on the basis of Gram-raj or non-violent village communism.

Nine selected speeches of Vinobaji are presented in this small booklet and they represent the ideological progression of the movement towards its great destiny.

Tanjore, } Sarvodaya Prachuralaya,
May 1956. } (Akhila Bharath
Sarva Seva Sangh).



Satyagraha and New Social Order

OUR ideal is to build up a society which does not need a coercive authority of the State. The Communists also believe that the State will ultimately wither away. But in the immediate present they are out to build a strong totalitarian State. There are others who feel it is an utopian idea which can never be brought to reality. There are some others who believe that man, as he is made, will always need some kind of a State.

In a non-violent Society, there is a minor place for the State. It may not disappear completely, but the chief thing is that in such a society, organisation based on service will have the most prominent place. I often wonder if an organisation like the Indian National Congress is really capable of ushering in a non violent society.

Gandhiji's Loka Sevak Sangh

Elections have great prominence in Congress organisation and the body that is devoting most of the time in electioneering can hardly be the instrument for creating a new non-violent society. Not only this, it may prove a danger to the growth of non-violence. That is why the Father of the Nation had advised us to turn it into a Loka Sevak Sangh immediately after attaining freedom.

We realise the wisdom and foresight of his suggestion to-day. We are trying to fill up the

vacuum by starting organisations like the Bharat Sevak Samaj. Small organisations devoted to social service existed even during the British rule and continue their work to-day. There are many such organisations in existence. But they are too small and scattered to provide a focal point for the expression of the non-violent will of the people.

The objective behind the Loka Sevak Samaj was that there must be a broad-based organisation which would win the love of the people by its selfless service. Such an organisation alone will be able to take the power of the State. All parties will try to get the good-will and support of such an organisation.

Unfortunately for us, such an organisation does not exist in the country at present. The Congress is completely obsessed and engrossed in elections. Probably it is natural and inevitable. There may be some justification for it. I do not want to go into it just now. I am only concerned with the fact that an organisation of this kind cannot be the instrument of creating a new society.

The Sarvodaya Samaj

Since the Congress failed to fulfil this great task, smaller men with limited capacities are compelled to come forward and create this nation-wide brotherhood of Sarvodaya Samaj, built on service. No one can run away with the idea that it is our intention to weaken any institution or organisation, political or otherwise. If friends feel that they are

wielding power by remaining in their posts they may continue to remain there. But they may realise soon that they do not wield power but would feel weak. They will surely come out and do so without delay. As long as there are parties built on differences of opinion, all of them must be well organised and strong. The good members of every party should try to give a minor place to election in the party work.

I must confess that I fail to understand the meaning of the one-man one vote in democracy. In formal democracy of this kind Pandit Nehru has one vote and his Chaprasi has one vote. No one will be able to convince me of the righteousness of such a procedure. It may be justified only on one ground. Only the Vedantin can justify it, for he believes that there is one *Atma* (Soul) in all. If we are out to change social values and build up a new society, elections will never achieve it.

Official Definition of Ahimsa

Ahimsa was the life-breath of Mahatma Gandhi. Whatever he did, he tested it on the touchstone of non-violence. Many of his lieutenants have taken on themselves the responsibility of the Government. They try often to define non-violence. Thus there is to-day an official version of non-violence. Their conception of non-violence is, I think, too negative. To cause least inconvenience or illwill seems to be their criterion of non-violence. When you say that prohibition must be enforced in a "go-slow" way, the consumption of drinks increases ten-fold. So

please spare Ahimsa from the 'go-slow' policy. This Fabian non-violence is a dangerous doctrine. It is possible to go slow in matters which are not clearly concerned with violence or non-violence. But if you are really serious about non-violence then there is no question of degrees, and gradual progression. It should be immediate, and wholehearted. It has to move with speed. I pray to God that people who really believe in non-violence will realise this.

Rajaji's call to America

Rajaji is a philosopher and a statesman, and he is also a master of words. He advised the President of the U. S. A. to discard the nuclear weapons unilaterally. The Americans are a learned people. Not only the rulers, but the voters are well educated. They consume 160 times more paper than we do. When Esinhower listens to Rajaji's advice, the people of America will be disillusioned and displeased. I agree with what Rajaji has said. Individually he has probably the right to say so, but I wonder if he can say as a representative of the Nation.

Pakistan has entered into a pact with America and increased its army. Do we feel the courage of disbanding our violent forces because Pakistan is increasing its armed strength? Can America, in the face of this, listen to a man who advises them to decrease their nuclear power? I submit we must create a strength and confidence in the Nation to act. This can never happen as long as non-violence is gradual. Non-violence certainly does not mean the continuation of the *status-quo*.

The Positive Satyagraha

The word Satyagraha has incurred the odium of many. We are told by some that there is no room for Satyagraha in democracy. I can understand this dictum if democracy meant unanimity. But I fail to understand how Satyagraha can be banned in the present formal form of democracy. Satyagraha that we practised under Gandhiji was certainly not the ideal Satyagraha. It was conditioned by the circumstances of the time. It was too negative in its approach. It was the genius of Gandhiji to link up constructive work with Satyagraha and make it its pre-condition. But after freedom it cannot remain negative. Negative Satyagraha will not serve our purpose to-day.

The Technique of Bhoodan

We have a certain technique for Bhoodan work. Suppose our mission is not achieved by 1957. What next is the question often asked by the workers. I say, you can ask the question only when you have put in concentrated collective efforts first.

As long as we have not done so where is the justification for such a question? Our task therefore is to give every ounce of our energy to the task in hand. I have no doubt that if we work with our heart and soul success would be ours. Bihar, Bengal and Utkal are eloquent testimony to my faith. All our scattered energies must be concentrated in our focal point. It is then only that we shall be able to take the necessary steps.

Appeal to People — the Masters of Legislators

With the coming of freedom our responsibilities have increased. We have to bear the responsibility to govern the country. I do not deny that. Those who have gone in for the elections and entered legislatures will mind the responsibilities of the Government. But those who want to bring about a radical change, should devote all their energy to Bhoodan. If we create a real public opinion and educate the people it will have much greater effect than the speeches in the legislatures. The key men may remain in place of power but all the rest must no longer delay in acting. Their place is with the people.

There are several burning problems of the day and those in authority give their own replies for them. For every question whether it is banning cow-slaughter or replacement of the textile cloth with khadi, their reply is foregone. They fling the slogan of public opinion at our face. They are right and it is for this that we must go to the public. The public are the real masters. You must give up approaching those who are their servants i. e. the members of the legislatures. They have to obey their masters, the people.

(Speech at Sarvodaya Sammelan at Puri)
25-3-'55

Sarvodaya Order by 1957

The All Powerful State

FROM the very early beginnings of human society love and hate had existed by side.

In the early stages it was unrestrained violence that held the faith. Gradually man learnt to curb and limit his violence and the institution called the State came into existence. The formation of the State did limit violence up to a degree. The advent of the apparatus of Government created a new kind of law and order. Even Vedas had said that coercive power of the State was personification of Dharma. But gradually the State grew stronger, became more and more powerful till it became an all-powerful state with the power of destroying the whole world with its military might based on nuclear weapons.

The Challenge of Violence

Never in the human history had man been so overpowered by fear as he is to-day. The Hydrogen bomb is the symbol of scientific progress and human servitude. Man is wondering how he could limit and tame the power of violence based on nuclear weapons. They were talking of putting a stop to the production of atomic missiles and weapons destroying those that are already in existence.

Freedom From Coercive State

It is an illusion to hope to limit or restrict or regulate the power of violence of the modern State.

The only rational and sensible alternative is to understand that humanity can exist only when it discards violent weapons and accepts the ideal of building up a society in which there is no coercive State. From years back I felt that it was an utopian ideal and would be realised only after a few thousand years but now I see that the world conditions have brought it so near. Without its immediate realisation human civilisation cannot survive.

If you read the writing on the wall and understand the way human history is being shaped you will see that the whole force of history is behind you.

The Alternative To Non-Violence

Violence cannot be limited. It cannot be ended. Destruction or the creation of non-violent society are the only two alternatives. Those who have these faith in humanity must have stout hearts and must have faith in the basic goodness of man. The very fact that you and I are talking of Bhoodan and going about all over the country collecting gifts shows that God has a plan and he does not want the world to be destroyed.

The inspiration and forces behind the movement are not yours or mine. It is the force of Nature, history, God or whatever you choose to call it. I call it a divine inspiration.

The Satyayuga is at hand. The Kaliyuga is over. This is being realised by men and women all over the world. Brotherhood, equality and a

non-violent society are the ideals that are moving millions in every country under the sun.

If an atom when activated can develop the strength to destroy the world, how much more powerful would the human atom be when it has the right intelligence.

The New Era of Sarvodaya

A new era is opening up before us. India seems to be in the centre of the stage. The work of peace that our Prime Minister is doing in the international field, the Bhoodan Movement and all the ferment that is growing in people's minds only express the deep thirst of man to find a way of living together.

We have pledged ourselves to collect five crores of acres of land by 1957. Many of you are worried and feel anxious thinking of our limited capacities. You are asking yourselves, 'how can we achieve such a big target in the next two years?'

Land-Gift For World-Peace

Believe me, I do not worry even for a moment. In fact, I hardly ever think in terms of five crores or ten crores of acres. After all, land gift movement is only a symbol. I have a faith within me that Sarvodaya society may come into existence all over the world by 1957.

When you go and ask for land donations you explain to everyone that you are taking land not only for solving the land problem of our country but

for establishing real peace in the world. Do not bother about land gifts. Find out if you have real faith in creating a non-violent order. If you have that within you, your faith will be irresistible and it will shine.

If the movement does not grow then the fault is yours. It is the lack of faith in a non-violent order that makes you weak. When Gandhiji lived, you could bury yourselves in your smaller activities whether it was khadi, basic education or the like. You live in your small spheres and are content to work like unknown warriors. But we are passing through a most critical period in the world and we have to put our shoulder to the wheel and concentrate all our energies on Bhoodan movement. I ask my colleagues not to tarry any further. Sands of time are running out. I wish some of you go back to your homes on foot and start explaining the message you have heard here to every man and woman whom you meet.

We must be afire with the zeal of determination to create the nucleus of a real non-violent society in India by 1957. Ours is an appeal to men and women all over the world who are trembling with fear of war and hunger for peace.

(Prayer speech on 27-3-'55 - Puri Sammelan)

Vinobaji's Appeal to the Congress

It gives me great pleasure to have had this unique opportunity of meeting you here. I am no believer in differences of caste, creed, language or party and to me everyone is a human being. Therefore I speak with friendly feelings to you, one and all and I hope you will take it in the same spirit.

Fear Psychology

The world today is seriously ill. Sometimes its condition becomes grave and sometimes we see hopes of recovery. Great men of the world are anxious that it may not lead to a conflagration. They are engaged in serious efforts to prevent such a calamity. It gives us pleasure to see that here and there their efforts are attaining some success. But the malady of the world is something deep-rooted. It cannot be cured by mere external treatment. Such treatment may give some relief now and then. But we have to remove the root cause of the disease in order to effect a permanent cure.

This is an age of power. Science has placed in the hands of man great power, or rather, man has been thrown in the hands of power. Power is controlling man and making him dance to its tune. This has led to a very serious situation. The whole of mankind is in the grip of a great fear. Perhaps this is the first time in history that fear psychology is pervading all over the world. Man can progress if he puts an end to this fear. We cannot seek a sylum from this fear in the stockpiles

of devastating weapons of war. Fearlessness cannot be achieved through the agency of weapons. The development of Ahimsa or soul force alone can lead man to fearlessness. One who fears cannot therefore be said to be non-violent. Man seeks the help of arms only in the absence of Ahimsa or soul force in him. This does not mean that if he abandons these arms he will become fearless. Fearlessness represents a state of mind which can be brought about only by a change in the way of man's thinking.

The Avadi Resolution

I was glad that the Avadi Congress Session passed a resolution on the socialistic pattern of society. What change that this resolution has brought about in the minds and lives of Congressmen who adopted it? That will be the real test of their having accepted this resolution. Otherwise such high-sounding words carry no weight.

Unilateral Action

Our leaders as well as our people are aligned on the side of peace. Great men like Rajaji are appealing to the world to take a bold step. The question is whether our country is advancing in that direction. Are we creating that strength in our country which could lay the foundation for a non-violent society? Here again the test will be whether the people are self-governing and whether only noble ideals rule their minds. Today all countries of the world are suffering from mutual fear and suspicion. To root out this fear and suspicion, some country

will have to take to unilateral action. Are we advancing our country in that direction? If we can do that, even within the next ten years, we will have shown the way to the world and the moral power thus created will lead the world to peace.

The Two Alternatives

It is neither possible nor necessary to check the progress of Science. Science should only be put under the control of moral power. If that happens, there is no fear from the unbridled progress of Science. These are the only two alternatives before the world: either we allow Science to advance or we check it, a little violence will not be out of place. In the past even saintly persons used violence in the interest of the community. No harm resulted from it; on the other hand, it resulted in good, because the use of violence was very limited. Willynilly, Science is going to advance. If we root out violence, the advance of Science can be beneficial; otherwise it must lead to destruction.

India's position is such that only her moral power can grow and not other forces. Either she develops her moral strength or she goes extinct. It is therefore I say that mere words cannot help us and we should bring about a change in the hearts of the people in their approach to various problems.

The Origin of the Movement

This question of change of heart had been occupying my mind since long and the idea of Bhoodan was the natural consequence of a long

search. When I was working among the Meos near Delhi, the landless Harijans among the refugees asked for land. We discussed the matter with the authorities and the Punjab Government promised to give land. I even made a public declaration of this fact at a prayer meeting at Rajghat. Two months later the Punjab Government went back on their word on the plea that there was not sufficient land even for those who originally possessed land in Pakistan. The Government was inclined to maintain only the *status quo*. This pained me much, as it pained the Harijans as well as many others. The Harijans thought of offering *sātyagraha* and sought my advice. I advised them against such a step and at the same time expressed my inability to help them in any other way. This was agitating my mind and I was in search of a method by which the landless could be provided with land. When Telangana gave me the hint, I took it up and started the Bhoodan movement.

Land for the Landless

The land problem is a basic problem not only for India but also for many Asian countries and if we can solve it in a peaceful manner, our non-violent strength will grow. The redistribution of land brings in its wake many other problems-economic and otherwise for which I have been looking for solutions. But seeking a solution to the land problem is not my only objective. I am more concerned with the non-violent technique that comes into play in this movement and I do not want this technique to slip away

through my fingers. If this method can create faith in Ahimsa, I think it will have a great effect on the world.

I do not want you to view this movement from the narrow outlook of party or personal interest but from a real spirit of service. I am asking for only one-sixth of the land for the present. This is not a big thing, which cannot be achieved within two years. If we put all our energy in this work and solve this problem within two years, the world will recognise the efficacy of Ahimsa. Our other problems also can be solved in a similar manner. I advise the constructive workers also to leave all their work and join this movement, because the success of this movement will prepare the basis for all items of the constructive programme.

Bhoodan—A Vote for World Peace

I consider the offerings of land with a real understanding of the principles and philosophy of Bhoodan, as vote for world peace. Some people pooh-pooh this idea and criticise me for linking Bhoodan with world peace. They recall what Gandhiji also said that the Bihar earthquake was the result of the curse of untouchability, and point out that connecting Bhoodan to world peace is similiar to connecting earthquake and untouchability. I do not want to go into the deeper significance of those words of Gandhiji, but wish to say in all humility that what I say is different.

Moral Power of India

India put up a non-violent fight for Independence and won it. This has raised the stature of

India in the eyes of the world, and today her voice is listened to with great respect. It is India's moral strength that has had this effect. What other power can she boast of? She neither possesses the vast military strength nor the huge wealth which some of the big countries of the world possess. Even then if she can make her voice heard, it is because of her moral power. If we solve our problems in the same non-violent way, our moral strength will grow still more.

Potentiality of Bhoodan

People from all parts of the world have begun to take interest in Bhoodan movement. Neither do I write about it in English nor do I correspond with foreigners. Still the news of the movement has spread all over the world. The world sees some rays of hope in it.

No one wants war. Still the race for armaments is going on unabated. The world is pining for a way out of this mire. It feels that Bhoodan might show the way for the peaceful solution of the ills of the world. What we have achieved is not big. Even the little we have achieved has created a hope in the world of a potential power in our movement for peace.

No Land-gift by compulsion

I have heard reports of compulsion and threats held out to landowners while approaching them for land. I do not want to collect land by such methods. There are other people who can adopt these methods and it is not necessary for us to wander on foot from

village to village. Therefore I have publicly declared that if any body holds out such threats or uses compulsion, people should refuse to part with their land. I do not want even a bit of land by such methods. We should approach the landowners with love. Whatever is given must be given with the full understanding of the philosophy behind Bhoodan. Then only it will have value.

Appeal to Congress

Every year I have been receiving invitations to attend the Congress Session. But I never attended; nor did I send any reply. This year too the same thing would have happened, had not somebody on his way to Avadi met me. I took the hint and sent a letter to the Congress expressing a hope that it would some day come to my help. The Congress President said that I had every right and claim to demand help from you, though I am not in the Congress. This is the first time that I attend the A. I. C. C. meeting and how can I have any right to ask for your help? But everyone will have to accept that Truth and Justice demand it.

Moving incidents in Bhoodan

It is generally accepted that the present distribution of land in our country is unjust. In my opinion land must be free like air, water and sunlight, and everyone must have a right to it. There should be no private ownership of land. Wherever I go, this is what I tell the people. They seem to appreciate this point of view. I have not come across a single

person who is opposed to this view. There may be some who may not part with their land immediately. But I have every hope that even they will give land, if not today, tomorrow. They cannot but give.

I remember here an incident which happened when we approached a Muslim landowner for land.

He said : "What is the principle underlying your demand for one-sixth of the land?"

I said to him : "I take it that ordinarily a family consists of five brothers and I consider myself as the sixth brother and demand my share on behalf of the landless."

He said : It is true that we are five brothers, but according to our religion, daughters also are entitled to a share in the property, and we have two sisters."

Then I said : "If you are seven, brothers and sisters, consider me as the eighth member and give me my share."

He immediately gave away the one-eighth.

I relate this incident here only to show how generous-hearted our people are. Such experiences have melted even my stony heart and I have been changed into a soft-hearted man. The realisation comes upon one that India's heart is essentially pure and sound and in it lies our future hope and strength.

It is my earnest appeal to you to devote the next two years to this work, setting aside all other preoccupations. Some people ask me whether they should give up all other work completely. I would tell such persons to take the spirit of my advice and not go merely by the letter. This is my advice even to the constructive workers. I have myself done constructive work for over thirty years and I can tell them that unless we build a basis for our work, it is not going to succeed. Till today nobody interested himself in our work. People talked of Sarvodaya as an ideal impossible of achievement. But now it appears to them to be practicable even in the present world and hopes have been created in their minds. I want the Congress to take up this work without any party spirit and carry it to success with the co-operation of all other parties.

Another point to which I wish to draw attention is the serious situation created by evictions. We have made it a point in our movement to approach such landlords, explain to them the wrong they are doing, ask for land gifts from them, and rehabilitate the evicted peasants on such land. If the landlords do not respond, we will have to ask the peasants to stick on to their land, whatever be the consequences. This may result in sufferings to the peasants. Therefore I want the Congress to take up this question also as part of the Bhoodan campaign.

A very remarkable result of Bhoodan is that about 100 villages have been completely offered in Bhoodan. This will lead to a new way of life, in

which nobody will enjoy what he possesses without first offering a portion of it to the community.

Government's Role

I have asked you to give two years to this work. It is not much. If anything is left undone at the end of this period, it will be done by the Government. In fact I do not want anything to be left incomplete. In that case I cannot consider the movement a complete success. I would like this problem to be solved through popular will alone. The Government will only give its seal of approval to the popular will. The Communists, while supporting this movement, suggest that I should bring pressure on the Government. If the Government has to complete the revolution, how can it be a triumphant end for the movement ?

In the end I appeal to you all to give your best attention to this work, so that the country can feel proud of a great achievement.

(Berhampur 9-5-'55)

The Time of Trial

Need for workers

TO day a friend came to me to offer some land. I told him that his gift was welcome, but would be pleased only when he became a worker of the Bhoodan movement. He replied that there were others, and when the need arose he would be willing to do his part of the work. I told him that we were in urgent need of his help, and that we could ill afford to lose a moment. If friends like him realising the urgency take up the work and accept the charge of twenty five villages, it can be safe hope of completing our work and solving the land problem in a few months.

Complete the work in each village

We hug on to our old habit of working in bits. We do not realise that we are in the age of Science, when every minute counts. The value of any work lies in its being done in time. Delay takes away the results of the work. We have barely two years of time and we have to prove that we Indians have enough strength to accomplish things. So, the mere collection of individual gifts, in these three years, should cease to be our work. By now three and a quarter lakhs of people have given us land gifts. That was good work in the beginning, but now every village should take up the responsibility of doing this work. Every village should now find out them who are landless, the extent needed, and how it should be collected. So people realising the seriousness should

accept the responsibility for this work, and go out in the neighbouring villages. The moral resources of their friends should help them to complete the work.

The Fire of Knowledge

During discussions this morning I said that our work was just like *Agni-pravesh* (leaping into fire). The forest fire consumes whatever comes in its way and reduces it to ashes. In Bhagavad Gita the Lord says that when *Gnyana* lits up, sin and ignorance are consumed by it not in stages but all at once. Good drives away evil outright. Small doses of good may drive out small doses of sin, but when *Gnyanagni* (the fire of wisdom) flares up, all evil is turned into ashes. These three years of Bhoodan work have washed away a little of our sin, and we have attained a little of *chitta shuddhi* (purity of heart). But now is the time for the flare-up of *Gnyanagni*. So I gave our friend a set of our books and asked him to study them. When the *Gnyanagni* flares up in him, he will do the rest, it being no concern of ours.

Spread literature everywhere

I wish *Gita Pravachan* is widely read in all the villages of Orissa, as well as by *Grama Sevaks*. Read them to those who cannot themselves read. We want workers to do this work apart from those who go for collection. They should go to the village, spread the literature on this ideal. In a way this is lighter work, for we need find a literate man and request him to read to others. When the ideology

is sufficiently spread, the work of collecting gifts becomes easy. So we will have three wings to our work : (1) Spreading the ideology, (2) Donors themselves collecting Dan, (3) Organising these items of work.

Revivalism through Purity of Heart

I have repeatedly said that this is *Bhakti Marga*, and through this, purity of heart is attained. If one attains purity, that purity will spread to others. Reconstruction of the society through heart purity is now what is being attempted. They who want to reform society, but do not realise the significance of the purity of heart, miss the more valuable part of the fruit, the seed. They are like those who want to harvest without sowing. There are some who think only of personal purity of heart without the thought of the reform of the society.

When one changes one's life it will influence others and they too will get changed. So the purification of the heart and change of life of one, will change the life of others and lead to the reformation of the society. This is our view of this work. Workers should understand this and come out for work; surely they will be richly rewarded.

(Address to Orissa Workers May 1955)

Self-Realisation Through Bhoodan

A worker who was with us for some days has now relinquished all his right to his land and is offering his services to Bhoodan work till 1957. This year's Sarvodaya Sammelan has given us the message to put aside all other work and leap into this work of Bhoodan.

We know that this work is of divine prompting and influenced by it many will come out to serve Daridranarayan. Serving Daridranarayan does not mean keeping poverty in perpetuity and giving doles to the poor. We mean the driving away of poverty and making Narayan universal. Those who come out to serve Daridranarayan will get the strength to make themselves poor and feel one with the poor. This voluntary acceptance of poverty is the sure way for driving out poverty. It does not surprise, me nor need this surprise anyone when young men throw away their wealth for their country and dedicate their lives to the service of the people.

Spiritual Realisation Through Bhoodan

With us is touring a Sanyasi who is scanning our work with a spiritual vision. He asked me whether his acceptance of Bhoodan work would lead to his spiritual realisation. Has Bhoodan the efficacy of bringing about spiritual realisation? Here is the example of the man who is now giving up his **property and taking up Bhoodan work.** He is not

a Sanyasi, yet he takes to the discipline of non-possession. The Vedas say that eternal existence or *Moksha* cannot be got by work, by possession, but only by giving them up. This is the way of social reconstruction also. When we aim at driving away poverty and affluence and we want the whole society to accept non-possession then such work cannot be done in small dribblets of constructive work.

Self-Abnegation

Till now the world has been thinking that sacrifice and non-acceptance are the disciplines of the Sanyasi. Bhagavad Gita wants that the fundamentals of *Sanyasa* should pervade the whole society. *Sanyasa* is not anything to be kept out of ordinary life, but should form the cardinal virtue of life. Renouncing the fruits of action should be the philosophy underlying all action, and giving up should be the basis of life. The seed by annihilating itself makes the tree grow. Likewise he who cannot give up his little self and cannot efface himself cannot accomplish anything great. The extinction of the seed is the cause of the growth of the tree. So *Sanyasa* has a great constructive force.

Spirit of Renunciation

We want to spread this spirit of non-possession and renunciation even among the kisans. We want every kisan to become a Sadhak—one disciplining himself spiritually. In agriculture there is a lot of work, and his life is a life of dedication to God. If he idles or exploits others his life ceases to be such

dedication. A life full of labour, a life of self-sufficiency, a life of helpfulness to others is indeed the life dedicated to God. Therefore this Bhoodan movement is giving young men the motive force to take to a life of sacrifice. This is generating a tremendous force.

After the attainment of Swaraj, a gloom of lethargy and helplessness has spread over the land. Now on account of the Bhoodan movement the spirit of sacrifice is receiving the proper emphasis. This is a good augury.

Social Dharma

It may be asked of us, if by non-possession, if by sacrifice, if by hard labour, spiritual perfection can be attained? In such a state only one thing will be wanting and that is non-egoism. Our answer is that if all work is done without the ego, life gets spiritually perfect. Our present social order stands self-condemned, and the society is breaking to pieces. Those who are in the routine of life are overwhelmed by ordinary attractions, and they accept them as their normal ends. They think that occasional doses of help to others will make their life righteous. Their whole life is one of self-indulgence. On the other hand there are a few who renounce completely, deny the bodily needs, but remain inactive doing no work. Thus life is cut into two sectors. We want all to accept a pattern of life which will be based on renunciation and enjoyment of needs. Life should be freed of egoism and be a dedication to the Lord. This is the full Social Dharma that we conceive of.

Herein all differences between spiritual and material life vanish, and a perfect social and spiritual order will prevail. This new idea has dawned on us, and so we call this work as *Dharma Chakra Pravartana*. It is our belief that those who understand this point begin this work.

Hunger of the Morrow or Hunger of the Neighbours ?

To-day everyone is thinking in terms of his property rights. But we say that such ideas should be given up, and all should think of the Society as the Lord owning all the rights. This will make them the devoted Bhaktas of the Lord Society. We should forget ourselves in the service of the society. Service should be based on self-discipline, and eating without physical labour should be considered a sin. We should not be thinking of the morrow this day. Let us think of our neighbours, the problems of the day. Let us do our work and eat what we get. If the neighbour is hungry to-day, we do not think of him, but we put by something for the morrow lest we should suffer from hunger tomorrow. Should we not think now of the hunger of our neighbour to-day? With the dawn of the morrow its problems can be solved with the grace of the Lord. Our putting by something to ward off our tomorrow's hunger becomes a social crime, a fraud on society and the Lord. Our sole faith should be in serving the society and man, and the Lord and the society will take care of us. Theft came in when man began to gather for himself,

Some ask us: 'Can you organise this perfect Social Order in a short time?' Then we answer that we are not the makers and that all combined can do it. We have no such egoism as to make us feel that we are the saviour of the world. The Lord is here to save the world, and with His grace a new idea has come to us which we are laying bare before you. If you accept the idea, act on it. We have immense faith in this idea, and young men are coming out giving up their property rights and for a life of non-acceptance. Every village should give me three or four Jeevandanis of this type, and we hope we will get them. We cannot and we wish not to do this work ourselves in every village. This work will be carried on by those who get this divine inspiration.

Appeal for Gram-dan

I am very happy to step into the Andhra Desa to-day. The Andras might take pride, that it was in their land that Bhoodan Yagna had its beginning. Bhoodan Yagna was started in Telangana which is only a part of Andra. Our Andhra tour has not yet commenced ; it will later. In between I got an opportunity to have a fore-taste of the conditions here for three days ;

The Village-Dan

I am now coming from Koraput and will be going back again there. Your Srikakulam district is close by Koraput. So it should be possible to realise the great achievements of Koraput in Srikakulam also. So far 250 whole villages had been received in Bhoodan Yagna in Koraput and it will be announced to-day that 70 more villages have been received. All these villages were not got without effort. It is the result of the toil of workers in village after village. The love that should have moved the donors is self-evident. They need no thanks from me ; but I should not fail to give thanks to all the workers who have worked to this end. They deserve my heartiest thanks for their incessant work ignoring the rains.

Koraput district is notorious for Malaria ; so the workers there frequently fall victims to it. All the same, it has become a habit with them to take rest when they are disabled and take up the thread

where they left it, soon after their recovery. I am not aware of any worker who has laid down the tools saying that he is no longer equal to the task. That Baba is wandering about unmindful of the rain has its effect on their minds. But while Baba is being given all facilities they have none. They have to wade through rivers, walk through forests to reach the various distant places. I said in one of the meetings of the workers that it was the army of monkeys that did the work of Sri Rama. Immediately the workers laughingly replied that we are doing the same and we will continue to do it.

As a result of all this the idea has caught a hold on the mind of the whole district and all are sympathetic towards the movement. I have also seen doctors attending on the workers very sympathetically when they fall ill. They say, "These are the Bhoodan workers. We do not know when we will get the opportunity to work in the movement. Let us at least contribute our little share by serving them." I am very thankful to all these doctors also.

When a great movement which aims at the uplift of all the people is going on, of course all should come forward to show sympathy and offer help. So we need not wonder at the spontaneous help that we are getting on all sides. And yet I feel called upon to express my thanks because our country has become a victim to laziness. As the movement has been before the country for four years now, it is but proper that it should attract general sympathy.

That is as it should be. But we have not had the requisite training to convert this sympathy into something concrete.

Thamoguna (lethargy) has entered into our blood. We take it to be Vedanta. But *thamoguna* is entirely different from Vedanta. They are as poles apart. We have plenty of sympathy and desire to help; but it has become a habit with us to sit with folded hands without doing anything and say that everything will be all right in the end. That is why I feel it necessary to thank all who have contributed in some way or other materially. I cannot express how happy I feel when I do so.

Tribute to Andhra

We have so far received one lakh acres in the Koraput District. The number of donors runs to more than 15,000. But I have told them that they should collect four lakh acres from at least one lakh donors. This is not an impossible target though a difficult one. It is only for achieving difficult tasks that we have been given the human frame by the Creator. Had He thought of making us do easy things He would have made us all beasts. Then we could have been content with eating, sleeping and satisfying the other natural instincts and died when our span of life ended. But it is only when a difficult task faces him that man is in his element and feels enthusiastic. I am sure that in Srikakulam, the abode of the Goddess of Plenty and Success as its name signifies, our efforts will be crowned with success and will not have to face defeat. Andhra

Desa has always been a land of heroes. From the historical times of Salivahanam to the present day of Prakasam and Sriramalu there have been a continuous line of heroes here. Therefore I do not think it is too much to hope that the people of this place will work unflaggingly.

The Gangothri of Bhoodan

I began this movement with the request that people should contribute 1/6th of their lands. Why, I did not mention of the 1/6th contribution in Telangana ; I only pleaded there for the loosening of the heartstrings a little. It was like Gangothri, the source of Ganga and I thought that the trickling stream will gather strength by and by as it goes along. But after sometime I began asking for 1/6th contribution, and while we had hardly got 20,000 acres, I fixed the target at 5 crore acres. Did I make such a tall demand relying on my own strength? I knew my limitations. I could not take this big decision in my own name. If then the decision was taken it was only because of my faith in you. Because it is a great, holy decision it is my hope that it will enthuse and make us work towards its fulfilment.

None landless

When the call for 1/6th of the land had reached all quarters, I began to say that there should be none in any village without land and all the landless should be provided with land.

None-the owner of Land

And now in the end I have begun saying that individual ownership of land should go and all land should belong to the villagers in common. I have raised this slogan in Utkal, and specially in Koraput. Thus, as you see, the stream of Bhoodan has gone on getting wider and wider and it should get wider still in great Andhra. Let nobody think that I go on putting up my demand as the merchants do. In fact this is not a new demand of mine at all. In my very first utterance in Telangana I had laid down the proposition that there can be no individual ownership over land and it should go. It assumed the shape of a practical programme by slow degrees and has grown to its present stature. But the idea has been there since a long time.

The Support of the Political Parties

You are seeing that in this out of the way village a large number of people from all parts of Andra Desa has assembled for offering welcome. It shows that the Andra Desa is fully ready to take up this work. The Congress people have told me that I need no longer think that I have been left to do this work single-handed, that it is as much their work as mine. After all I am only an individual unattached to any institution. I have no authority or power over any institution. It is only the love that actuates the Congressmen that is responsible for their offer. The Praja Socialists are also sympathetic towards this work. They have gone

to the extent of saying that I have taken what is really their own programme from out of their hands. I do not refute their charge but only say to them "I plead guilty ; but at the same time my request to you is not to give up your programme on the plea that I have taken it up." I am glad that they are doing what all they could for furthering this work. I have said 'what all they could' advisedly because I find to my sorrow that their party to-day is going to pieces. But it does not matter. Even now if they engaged themselves in this task with their whole heart they can regain the ground they have lost of late. After all any political party which aims at gaining popularity and influence throughout the length and breadth of this land should take up some programme which has the service of the common people as its aim. So I hope that these people will not fail to help to the best of their ability.

The attitude of the Communists

I believe that even the Communists will show sympathy and contribute their share. They are idealists hence it is but natural that they are not ordinarily satisfied with small gains. If they examine our work dispassionately and are satisfied that some real work which helps the poor and the down-trodden to raise their heads is being done here, I have no doubt, that many from among them will offer help. As regards the Sarvodaya workers I believe that they will dedicate their all to this movement because they will find whatever they call ~~their own~~ ^{their own} their ideals and ambitions—are

imbedded in this. Their success lies in the success of this movement and they will be nowhere if this movement fails. Even those who are identified with the Government, who are in its service can help to some extent. Because no Government can afford to stand aside and look on unmoved by a great movement when the service of the people as its aim is in full swing. Many from among the common people also will come forward to take part.

Appeal to Sarvodaya Workers

But I want to tell you to-day something special. Many might come forward to work, in this movement. But I would lay down a condition for all. It is this : that the workers should be soft and gentle in their speech.

They should be sweet and kind in their approach. Their hearts should be full of love and sympathy. There is no place for any compulsion, threatening or reprimand.

This applies to the Government servants, Congress and Sarvodaya workers and equally to all who are engaged in this. Nobody should imagine that he has got special powers to order people about. If anyone takes up this work under the wrong impression that he can achieve his end by resorting to these violent methods he will invite not only his own end but also the end of the whole movement. Are we not asking the people to give

up their all? This is a highly effective prescription, a very powerful medicine. When one is given a very powerful and effective medicine the concomitant conditions will also be exacting. In the refrain (Namvali) that our Sadhu Subrahmaniam sang just now the same idea is contained in its essence : "ALL IS RAMA, THERE IS NOTHING IN THE WORLD BUT RAMA." We should never forget this while we are engaged in the Bhoodan work.

7—8—55

The Origin of Bhoodan

The first day of Bhoodan

I SAW that on a simple demand from the villagers of Pochampalli, Sri Ramachandra Reddi of the same village, stood and announced his first Bhoodan. "Was it but a phenomenon or was there any suggestion concealed in that act" I asked myself.

Here are some villagers who ask for eighty acres of land and here is a man who donates hundreds instead. Is it unthinkable that this process is repeated everywhere? Certainly not, if the people only possess the power to speak out their minds. Man does not act on the strength of his individual thinking alone. There is a preparation going on in the surrounding world, which prompts his action. "The donor of the village had no doubt become the immediate and effective cause; but, may be, the atmosphere also, is ready in the world for such a programme."

Nature's planning is never partial. It is perfect upto the mark. When it gives appetite to the child, it not only provides the mother with the necessary food but also inspires her to feed the child.

And suddenly came the flash: And I realized that the world power beckons us to fulfil some new mission.

Do I possess the necessary strength to carry out the new mission, which I do not have?

But what if I do not possess the strength? Do I not possess the faith? I thought.

There were but hundred acres in my hand. My love of Mathematics led me, even in that serious mood of meditation, to calculate to approximate figure needed for the total landless population of India. And I found that about five crores would be sufficient. That means, the three figures of today must rise to five hundred thousand times more. Should I now shirk the fear of the figures or take the hint? If I am blind to the suggestion, I must give up my faith in non-violence and accept violence as my new creed or should turn a pessimist. I was prepared for neither. With heart within and God over-head, I fell fast asleep.

The Second Day

At the next halt, I repeated my new idea to my audience. I had originally planned to have only a first-hand knowledge of the conditions in Telangana. I had no idea of Bhoodan whatsoever. But I realised and was more than convinced, that if non-violence was to survive, I must take the hint underlying the phenomenon. Even the monkeys carried on Rama's mission. Am I not qualified even as much as the monkeys were, if not better, bestowed with human qualities as I am, a man of living faith in non-violence, and one who had been a devotee of these monkeys as well? Therefore,

he who could employ the monkeys, shall take work from me also, provided I reduce myself to nil, void of any age and pride in me, as was the case with the monkeys.

Thus even at this second village, I stretched out my hand to demand land, as a son would do to the father. The villagers never knew my mind, and were present with garlands to offer to me. I pointed out to them that though beautiful were the flowers in their hands, Earth, the mother of these flowers, was indeed more beautiful. While flowers were meant for the Lord's worship, I ask for land only. 'I am your son' a member of your family. If you have four, give unto me my fifth share.

They were all taken by surprise. But my words had the effect which the Atom Bomb had in Hiroshima. They gave me sixty acres. Only yesterday I had received one hundred. Today sixty. Euclid's two points were present and the Line was complete.

After Four Years

Four years have since elapsed, and the donations steadily rose from the hundred to a thousand and then to a lakh, making today a total of forty lakhs contributed by four and a half lakh donors. Granted that one amongst the hundred who listened to the message of Bhoodan parted with his or her land, the idea has reached atleast to four and half crores of people. My experience in Bihar is indeed

a pointer of the dawn of Satyayug. People actually complained that while they wanted to give, none approached them for land. It is not I who had made people's mind conscious. It has been there ready and willing to respond.

Sarvodaya Personified in Mother

We have to take an all round view and should learn to look from all angles. The idea of Sarvodaya is absolute and complete in itself. It conceives universal equality and fraternity and dismisses any conception of high and low. Like the Vaishnava who regards all but him as great and himself small, the believer in Sarvodaya considers all greater than himself. 'Let all eat first, mine turn shall be the last. That is the way of his thinking. People ask if the idea could ever be realised. Was it not realised even today in our houses? Who is our mother, if not 'Sarvodaya' personified? People want to be trained in Sarvodaya ideology at the training camps. That is not wrong. But is not the mother an ever flowing stream for such training? With every food, from her womb she initiates the child in Sarvodaya. She eats only after everyone else has done. This approach of the mother is the approach of Sarvodaya. Every mother thus presents a picture of Sarvodaya and there is nothing difficult in realising the ideal. What is needed is but the social application of the individual's approach. It is a wrong notion that the interests of the individual clashes with that of the Society. No mother ever

complained that her interest clashed with those of her children. May be the so-called economist has no place in her theory. But is it not high time for us to realise that our self-interest is best served through the fulfilment of larger society interests?

Decentralisation of Power

Swaraj has come. But do people feel the warmth of it? The very term Swaraj, or self Government, implies decentralisation of authority. The principle has, therefore, to be applied to every practicable limit, to all fields of life, social, economic, and political. Gramdan, or Villagisation, brought to their very cottages the power that really belonged to them, but of which, unfortunately, they were not conscious, and which, again not less unfortunately, indeed, was progressively centralised at places like Delhi and Kurnool, resulting in the progressive decline of their liberty and progressive rise in their poverty and sufferings. It is through Gramdan alone that the Delhi Raj of today could be transformed into the Gram Raj and Ram Rajya. Every State would then become a State in miniature with all the departments efficiently functioning in the village itself.

Appeal for Gramdan

Think not in terms of quantitative return of our ideal. See that it is properly divulged and firmly rooted in the hearts of the people. Let them fully grasp the concept of Bhoodan, and you will be surprised at the response that would be forthcoming. Don't you see that we asked them for Gramdan,

and they have responded. We have asked them to participate in Sampattidan and they are doing. Ask them to sacrifice their lives, and they will not fail us. Did they not respond to the Quit-India call and lay down even their lives at the altar of their country? They will certainly do so now. Our men are not wanting in their love for their brothers. They have been in one form or other manifesting their compassion which is the very basis of our mission. They rejoice in feeding the hungry, in clothing the naked, in nursing the ailing and in housing the destitutes. There is indeed, no dearth of compassion, which, in its process of evolution, has now reached the mark when it demands the very elimination of the cause of all these sufferings. Bhoodan's potentialities in this direction have been now amply proved, and Koraput has reduced all the castles of argumentation in this behalf, to ashes. The fire, when spreads, will envelop not only Utkal, but whole of India, and the world itself. Do not, my brothers, therefore, worry about the harvest that would indeed be plenteous. The reapers alone would be lacking.

Like the line of a circle, which meets at the starting point, may this Bhoodan which had its inception in Andhra, see its happy termination in the very land of Vishal-Andhra, and which could easily be realised through Gramdan.

Parvathipuram—October '56

The Five Stages Of Bhoodan

BHOODAN yagna was started in Telengana four years and three months back. It was commenced under the special conditions obtaining there then. There land-owners and cultivators were at loggerhads, were inimical towards each other. The movement started there with the view to remove this bitterness. The country had the experience of a new idea. This was the first step.

The second step was taken thereafter. When it began to spread it had its influence on the whole country. My trek to Delhi and the work done in its course was the second step which attracted the whole country and it had wide propaganda effect.

Then it was necessary to create confidence in the minds of the workers and I turned my attention to it. So a target of 5 lakhs of acres for Uttar Pradesh and 25 lakhs for the whole country was fixed. Both the targets were duly reached and this created self-confidence in the workers. This then was the third step. Then an attempt was made to collect one-sixth of the agricultural land in Bihar so that all the landless could be given land. A great deal of work was done in Bihar which cleared the way for us. That lakhs of acres could be collected in a province and lakhs of people will come forward to give away their lands was actually seen in Bihar. I do not attach so much importance to the extent of land collected as to the fact that about three lakhs of people had donated. The number of donors carries a value of its own. It created in the minds

of the people the feeling that the movement has vitality and is bound to spread. I bore witness to lakhs of people giving away their lands most willingly. It is natural that when in the sea the tide rises some dirt will also be mixed with it. So it may be possible to pick out particular gifts and say that these were given from special motives. But we should not lose sight of the wood for the trees. There have been enough number of donors who have contributed from the purest of motives. After all how can one expect greater selflessness among the donors than in the people in general ?

But I believe that the work done there has created a sense of righteousness and justice everywhere. Our demand for one sixth of the land has not yet been fulfilled but the workers there have not gone to sleep; they are at it still, very actively indeed. The test has come to them, since I left Bihar; and and I have every hope that they will come out with flying colours. The distribution of lands has just commenced there. This will bring in more lands and the atmosphere will get changed. The way for solving the land problem would then have been opened once for all. It is no small gain that whenever the workers sit down to think, they think only in terms of giving land to the landless. Though the work has not yet been completed, there are indications that it will soon be. The atmosphere has changed. As I have said already, there is an urge in the air throughout the State which can be used to advantage by the Government for enacting the

necessary laws. Herein we see the fourth step of the Bhoodan Yagna completed.

Now the fifth step is being taken here in Orissa. We see the flashes of revolution in the work that is being done here, which will change all the villages into well-knit families. The economists will rack their brains to find out a proper term to express this unique phenomenon but I have no such difficulty. I simply call it the 'village family.' The feeling of family is very strong everywhere in India, and we have simply to develop it and give it a wider content so as to embrace the whole village. Then will the foundation for the establishment of the Gramarajya have been laid to which end all our activities have so far been directed. Then we shall have to commence the raising of the super-structure. Hence it is that I call the work being done here as the last and final step.

It does not mean that we have come to the end of the journey and we will have no more work to do. On the contrary our work will commence only now. All these were the preliminary, mere preparations without which we cannot hope to achieve the end we have in view. We did not think merely of giving some succour to the famished, some relief to the suffering notwithstanding the fact that our work will result in giving relief and succour. Our aim is the building of non-violent mass strength. That strength we cannot build except by transforming the villages into well-knit family units. That is why I have been in quest of a means for this end for long years past. I have been thinking

and thinking where and how to begin. I have given about thirty years of my life to the service of the villages, and I have thought about the problems facing them as deeply as I could. I have been a believer in soul force and continue to be such even to-day. But we were not free then ; so I thought we can do something worthwhile only after attaining Swaraj. We are now free, the crushing burden has been removed from our shoulders, and favourable conditions have been created for generating mass strength.

It has been given me to build up the five steps of Bhoodan Yagna because the foundation had already been laid in my thirty years' village work. Whenever we receive whole villages as gifts we can straight away start all our activities like Khadi, Village Industries, Basic Education etc. That is why when I saw that something could be done here, I extended my stay. I have asked of the whole of India to contribute one-sixth or five crore acres of land and thereby a great work would be done. But even then, had there not been the whole-village gifts that we are now having here, we would have been obliged to think of some other means for generating mass strength. My call for five crore acres still stands, and it is my wish that all the people of the whole of India complete the quota at the earliest. I appeal to the Congress, the Praja-Socialist and the other political parties who believe in this movement to put in their utmost might and complete this work. This will result in what I would call "extensive

work." But whole village gifts mean "intensive work." Extensive work also should go on and I have given it as much momentum as I could in the last four years. It is a matter for pleasure, that various organizations and institutions have begun to think of this work. It is the grace of God Almighty that the intensive side of the work also is being given a push here. It is my belief that Kora-put will show the way for the whole of India to follow.

Thus, the first step was aimed at the removal of a local grievance. I call it by the name of *Palliative*. The second step had the aim of creating wide sympathy and understanding and attracting the attention of the whole country. I have given it the name of *Calling Attention*. The third step was to create self-confidence in the workers. I have called it *Fortification of Faith*. The fourth step was taken with a view to see how far we succeeded in collecting one-sixth of the available land. I have given it the name *Extensive Land-gift* and the fifth step is to convert whole villages into families. Then will commence Grama Rajya and Rama Rajya. This I have called *Land Revolution*.

Now that the fifth step has been taken, the workers will have no occasion to complain that they have no programme to work. One with zeal and enthusiasm will now have so much work that he can hardly find time even for rest. Hence it is that the septagenarian worker of Gujarat, Shree Ravi Sankar Maharaj has said that he has now hopes of living to complete a century.

Some villages have given one-sixth of the land. I am not at all surprised that they have not yet had the urge to give whole villages. When these will see what excellent work is being done in villages which have been gifted away en-block, I have no doubt, village after village will approach us and ask us to take them also. So let us not try to get thousands of villages just now. On the other hand, let us fix a time-limit, collect as many villages as we can and straight away start work in them. I have asked the workers here to prepare a blue-print for their future work before I leave the district. We cannot now say exactly how many villages will not then come in when the work would be started as per plan. Those who are now giving land-gifts are doing so out of faith, from a realisation of the idea behind the movement. The future donors will give after actually seeing the results. Then there will be need for propaganda for making people give whole villages. The actual work will serve as its own propaganda.

Therefore it is, that I want the workers here to develop in themselves an independent, crusading spirit. When people are prepared to give their all, the workers also should develop their power for sacrifice and love. Their knowledge and devotion to the cause will be put to very severe test. The workers will now have to think of giving their all in the service of the villages. They might have made great sacrifices for Swaraj; but this movement will demand of them greater sacrifices. I believe that new workers will come up

to take up this new work, and they will mostly come from the villages. In the past movements the workers came mostly from the middle classes and from the cities. They will be there in this movement also; but a greater number will come from the villages. When every village will have workers springing from its own soil the reconstruction work that they will do will be wonderful indeed! Because there is no limit to their capacity for sacrifice. The people of the upper classes also do sacrifice but they always reserve and preserve a portion of their wealth for enjoying themselves. But they of the villages know naught but toil and tears. So when the spirit of service will awake in them we will see the age of Krishna dawning anew on this land of destiny. I have full belief that when village construction work will commence after the village-gift movement, we will witness scenes reminscent of Gokul and Brindavan of yore in every village and hamlet.

(Translated from Hindi) - Koraput, dated 23-7-'55

Sarvodaya Through Village-Dan

WHATSOEVER be our religion, language, caste or creed, we are the sons of the same Father. We are all related to one another. But to-day we have forgotten that one Father—the Lord of all creations. That is why we couldn't get united and become happy. Our society have become partitioned into three separate divisions. Some are called the high class, some the middle-class and those at the bottom, the low class. The high class people have nothing but contempt for their brothers of the low class. Rarely they show any affection towards these poor brothers with whom they have to be in contact in their every day life. They think and say "these people are fools, they have no brain in them to work intelligently, they are idle and often do steal ; they have no respect for truth ; they have to be supervised, or else they won't work properly ; if they are given money they won't use it discreetly but will squander and waste it." They are thus simply considered as beasts of burden.

People of the low-class think that those of the high are cruel, wicked and deceitful. They work in their fields and shops and do often praise them in their face though they don't like them and have nothing but hatred towards them in their hearts. For help they go to the high-class people and if it is not received they abuse them. If help is given they say "yes to-day they have given us help, but tomorrow they will take it back in hundred folds from us. Who knows what all sufferings at their hands are in store for us ? "

Thus each cannot live without the other though the one above condemns the one below and the one down hates the one above.

These three divisions in society should give up their wrong attitudes towards each other. They should forget their differences and become one identifying with each other. Then only society will become strong. They should co-operate with willing hearts and thus serve as the strong and equal props of the tripod of society. Bhoodan is aiming to achieve this. We appeal to those who have enough of physical strength to offer their willing labour to the good of the whole society. We appeal to the rich and wealthy to voluntarily offer Sampattidan for the common benefit of all. We persuade the owners to voluntarily surrender their right of ownership over land and accept the ideal that land can be owned by society alone.

Our people, whether they belong to the high, middle or low-class, have one good trait in them and that is faith and devotion to Dharma. They put implicit faith in the words of good and saintly persons. Once they understand truth and the real Dharma, they begin at once to practise it. We have to go from village to village, door to door and make the people understand the basic ideal behind Bhoodan. This is real Satyagraha and we should go on doing it with love in our hearts and faith in truth and in the ideal. It should be done till all understand us. Our people are such that once they get the light and realize their Dharma, they will be quick to act and none can wean them away in any other direction. Thus our society is now getting reformed day by day.

The days of violence and loot are fast disappearing. Changed values of life are being

recognised now in our society. People are offering me land. What strength is there in me but that of truth and love. More than 200 villages have been offered to me so far in this district as full gramadans by the villagers.

Wherever full villages are received for Bhoodan, there will be no more of the richman's contempt for the poor, the poor man's hatred for the rich or the jealousy or rivalry among the middle class. All become equals. There will be none high, none low, and none in between the two. Of course there will be some differences but such variations will be only such as are found in the five fingers of the hand. All the fingers co-operate and jointly do a lakh and odd things. People should co-operate and jointly work like the five fingers; they should live as the five Pandavas lived; they should mix and mingle like the five elements of nature. When this happens our society will become free of scorn, hatred and rivalry and there will be love, respect and co-operation alone between individuals. Then every one will grow and all will become equal. Such is the Sarvodaya Order of Society. Such of those villages that are offered as full *dan* will witness this real picture of Sarvodaya. In them all the villagers will say that all land in the village belongs to the village in common and all wealth and intelligence of the people therein will be utilized for the benefit of all in the village. Each will feel that he lives for others, and he will not think of himself but will think of others. And every one in the village will look after every other and the common good of the village will be the one concern of each and every therein.

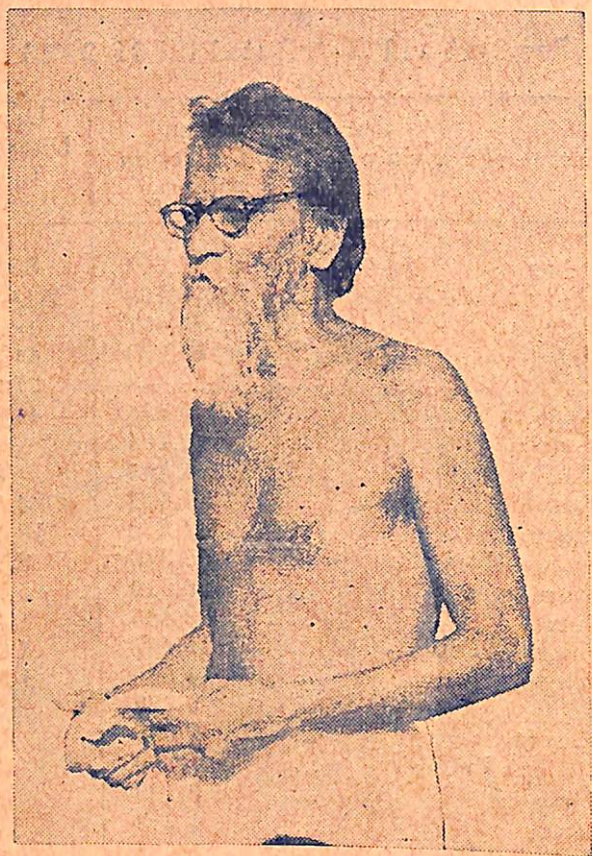
(Speech on 12-1-'55 at Meghina—Koraput, Orissa.)

All India Bhoodan

Received and Distributed till 31-3-'56

Name of Province.	Land Collection Acres.	Land Distribu- tion Acres.
1. Bihar ...	24,41,684	85,690
2. Uttar Pradesh ...	5,76,728	1,14,174
3. Rajastan ...	3,74,667	18,049
4. Utkal ...	2,85,029	41,378
5. Hyderabad ...	1,52,664	37,044
6. Madhya Pradesh ...	1,35,265	41,907
7. Andhra ...	50,754	...
8. Madhya Bharat ...	47,505	678
9. Tamil Nad ...	47,092	4,582
10. Gujarat ...	44,252	10,886
11. Maharashtra ...	30,846	3,983
12. Sourashtra ...	30,819	5,818
13. Kerala ...	28,465	1,426
14. Punjab - Pepsu ...	15,497	1,010
15. Bengal ...	11,580	1,963
16. Delhi ...	9,388	157
17. Mysore ...	9,065	100
18. Vindhya Pradesh ...	8,370	927
19. Karnatak ...	3,729	559
20. Assam ...	1,950	...
21. Himachal Pradesh ...	1,564	21
22. Bombay ...	578	...
Total ...	43,07,491	3,70,352

Total number of Villages donated : 1037



Acharya Vinoba

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